

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART ONE · STORY

CHAPTER 2 · TIME

Time as the thing holding the film together

HOLLYWOOD BLVD. · THE ROAD THE ROOM TOOK

Dunkirk · 2017 · 106 min · written and directed by Christopher Nolan

This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you press play" and resume after the credits.

THE TWO ROADS

STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner, and this one went straight on.

HOLLYWOOD BLVD.

VOTED

DUNKIRK

2017 · 106 min · written and directed by Christopher Nolan · Warner Bros.

🏆 WON 3 ACADEMY AWARDS IN 2018: FILM EDITING, SOUND EDITING, SOUND MIXING

Four hundred thousand men are pinned on a beach in northern France with the sea in front of them and the German army closing behind. The film follows the escape from three places at once, on the sand, on the water and in the air, and each of the three is running for a different length of time.

BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

Optional trivia.

THE SCRIPT WAS 76 PAGES

The industry rule of thumb is roughly a page a minute, so 76 pages should give you a 76 minute film. This one runs 106. The gap is the whole character of the thing, because what fills those extra thirty minutes is action rather than talk.

DIALOGUE WAS HARD TO SHOOT

IMAX 70mm cameras are enormous and extremely loud, which normally rules them out for anything with talking in it. Nolan wanted the format more than he wanted the conversations, so the format won, and what he ended up making is close to a silent film built in the twenty first century.

HANS ZIMMER RECORDED NOLAN'S WATCH

The ticking under the score is a real recording of one of Nolan's own pocket watches, run through synthesisers. Laid over the top is a Shepard tone, an audio illusion of a note that rises forever without ever actually getting higher.

WHILE YOU WATCH

Four moments, framed so the ticking clock conversation happens in real time while you are still watching rather than afterwards.

FIRST TWO MINUTES

The film tells you the rule out loud

Three title cards, one for each strand. **The Mole, one week. The Sea, one day. The Air, one hour.** The whole structure is handed to you before anything has happened, in typography, before a single character has been introduced.

THROUGHOUT

Has this already happened?

Three stories are running at three different speeds. So every time the film cuts, ask yourself one question, and keep asking it.

| Is this happening now, or has it already happened?

THE AIR

When the pilot starts writing on his own dashboard

Early in the air strand an instrument stops working, and the pilot begins keeping track by hand, in chalk, on the panel in front of him. From that moment the film has a countdown you can read with your own eyes, attached to a man who cannot stop it or refill it.

| It is the clearest clock in the film, and it is a piece of chalk.

THE LAST REEL

Does the clock ever stop?

The film has been ticking at you for an hour and a half.

| Does the clock stop at any point? And if it does, why there?

AFTER YOU WATCH

Everything below gives away how the film was made. Keep it for after the credits, or print the paper edition and read it on the way home.

LOCATION

It was shot on the actual beach

Nolan took the production to Dunkirk itself and filmed on the real sand at Malo-les-Bains. The Mole you see is a genuine stone jetty at the western end of that beach, rebuilt for the film with the wooden superstructure it carried in 1940.

The rest went to places that still look like 1940. Weymouth Harbour in Dorset stood in for the departure point, chosen because its Georgian waterfront had barely changed. The controlled water work went to the IJsselmeer near Urk in the Netherlands, and the interiors were shot on the Universal backlot lake and in Warner Bros Stage 16, which holds a two million gallon tank.

PRACTICAL

Real ships, real Spitfires, and some cardboard

Twenty of the original Little Ships that were actually at Dunkirk in 1940 were brought back for the film. The Spitfires are real Spitfires, and Nolan put IMAX cameras in the aircraft rather than building the dogfights digitally.

Where the crowds needed to look bigger than the several thousand extras on hand, the production filled the distance with cardboard cutouts. Chapter one had little people standing in as mechanics to fake the depth of an airfield in 1942. Same instinct, seventy five years apart.

What it cost and what it won

A hundred million dollar budget, against 530 million worldwide, which made it the highest grossing film about the Second World War until Nolan passed himself with *Oppenheimer* in 2023.

Eight Academy Award nominations including Best Picture and Best Director, and three wins. **Film Editing, Sound Editing and Sound Mixing**. Every award it took was for time and rhythm, which is worth sitting with for a second given what the film is about.

- 01 Is the clock in this film part of the plot, or is it a decision made in the edit? And does the difference change how you feel watching it?
 - 02 There is almost no dialogue and almost no backstory. Did you care about anyone, and if you did, what made you care in the absence of either?
 - 03 The film tells you its structure in the first two minutes. Would it be a better film if it hid that, or would it fall apart?
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THE OLDEST RULE IN THE BOOK

ARISTOTLE DESCRIBED A HABIT

Writing about Greek tragedy around 335 BC, Aristotle noticed that a tragedy *"tries as hard as it can to exist during a single daylight period, or to vary but little."* He is describing a tendency in plays that already existed, the way you would say most pop songs run about three minutes, which is taking notes rather than issuing instructions.

ITALY TURNED IT INTO A LAW

In 1570, an Italian scholar named Lodovico Castelvetro published a translation of the *Poetics* with his own commentary attached, and in that commentary the observation hardened into a requirement, that a play must happen inside a single day. Joined with unity of place and unity of action it became the three unities, and it went out under Aristotle's name rather than Castelvetro's.

FRANCE ENFORCED IT FOR A CENTURY AND A HALF

French classical theatre made the unities the standard of serious drama, argued them in public, and treated the writers who ignored them as amateurs. For roughly a hundred and fifty years the most influential theatre in Europe ran on a deadline one man inferred from another man's notes.

Chapter one found the three act structure published as a rulebook in 1979, thirty seven years after *Casablanca* was shot without one.

[Read more about unities](#)

THREE WAYS A FILM CAN RUN A CLOCK

What actually separates them is the relationship between *story time*, meaning how long the events take, and *screen time*, meaning how long you sit there. Dunkirk is doing more

than one at once.

ONE

THE DEADLINE

A time inside the story that somebody has to beat. Screen time stays free to compress or stretch, and the film cuts across the boring parts while the deadline holds.

High Noon · Apollo 13 · Speed

TWO

REAL TIME

Screen time and story time are locked to the same length. The film cannot cut forward, so it has to fill every minute it claims.

The Set-Up · Rope · Cléo from 5 to 7 · 24

THREE

THE LOOP

The same span of story time runs more than once, so the clock resets instead of running out, and the tension moves to what changes on the next pass.

Groundhog Day · Source Code · Edge of Tomorrow

○ STORY TIME ● SCREEN TIME

1 · THE DEADLINE



2 · REAL TIME



3 · THE LOOP



The fourth case is running more than one of these at once, which is what Dunkirk is doing.

ONE PIECE OF VOCABULARY

Writers separate a *time lock* from an *option lock*. A time lock ends the story when the clock runs out. An option lock ends it when the character runs out of things to try, which can feel identical from the seat even though nothing is counting down. Worth deciding, somewhere in the second half, which one you are actually watching.

WHY THIS IS THE FILM FOR IT

Dunkirk is running three of these at the same time, at three different lengths, which means every cut is asking you to hold a position in three separate countdowns at once. Chapter one was about the shape a story is supposed to have. This one is about what happens when a film stops using shape to organise itself and starts using duration instead.

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Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com

Facts in this guide are drawn from Academy records, BFI and university programme notes, contemporary trade reporting and interviews with the filmmakers. Where sources disagree, the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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